

FAMILY TOGETHERNESS WEEK OF PRAYER
SEPTEMBER 7-13, 2025

GOD'S *great* GIFTS

I WILL GO WITH MY FAMILY:

CELEBRATE CREATION:
MARRIAGE, FAMILY, AND THE SABBATH

GOD'S
great
GIFTS

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Willie and Elaine Oliver: Editors
Karen Holford: Principal Contributor
Dawn Venn: Senior Editorial Assistant
Daniel Taipe: Design

2025 AFM Resource Book Addendum

ISBN 978-0-8127-0585-0
JUNE 2025



Adventist®
Family Ministries

GENERAL CONFERENCE OF SEVENTH-DAY ADVENTISTS

12501 Old Columbia Pike, Silver Spring, Maryland 20904, USA

301.680.6175 office

family@gc.adventist.org

family.adventist.org



@Adventist.Family



/AdventistFamilyMinistries



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INTRODUCTION

In the beginning, God's heart overflowed with love, and that love found its ultimate expression in three magnificent gifts that would crown His work of creation: marriage, family, and the Sabbath. While the first six days of creation week reveal God's power and artistry in forming the physical world, it is these three divine institutions that reveal the very heart of His character and His deepest desires for humanity.

"For God so loved the world that He gave His only begotten Son, that whoever believes in Him should not perish but have everlasting life" (John 3:16). This verse captures the essence of

God's giving nature—a nature that was evident from the very beginning when He established these sacred gifts as the foundation for human flourishing.

Throughout creation week, we witness an intentional progression. Light conquered darkness, waters were separated to create sky and sea, dry land emerged with abundant vegetation, celestial bodies marked time and seasons, and creatures filled every corner of the earth. Each day built toward a crescendo, preparing the perfect stage for God's masterpiece: humanity created in His own image.

But God wasn't finished. After breathing into Adam the breath of life, the Creator

made a profound declaration: "It is not good that man should be alone" (Genesis 2:18). In forming Eve as Adam's perfect companion, God established marriage—the sacred union between one man and one woman that would become the cornerstone of human society. This wasn't merely about companionship; it was about reflecting God's own relational nature and creating the foundation for family life.

Marriage naturally gave birth to God's second crowning gift: family. Within the safety and love of this divine institution, children would be nurtured, faith would be transmitted, and the image of God would be passed from generation to generation. The family became God's

chosen method for filling the earth with His love and character.

Then came the ultimate crown: the Sabbath. After six days of creative work, God rested on the seventh day, blessing and sanctifying it. “The Lord has appeared of old to me, saying: ‘Yes, I have loved you with an everlasting love; therefore with lovingkindness I have drawn you’” (Jeremiah 31:3). The Sabbath represents this everlasting love made tangible—a weekly invitation for families to rest in God’s presence, to remember His goodness, and to prioritize relationship over productivity.

These three gifts—marriage, family, and Sabbath—stand as God’s

crowning acts of creation because they address humanity’s deepest needs: companionship, belonging, and communion with the Creator. Together, they form a trinity of divine institutions that continue to bless and sustain us today, reminding us that we are fearfully and wonderfully made and loved by our Creator (Psalm 139:14).



Adventist®
Family Ministries

Willie and Elaine Oliver, Directors
Seventh-day Adventist Church
World Headquarters



If you would like to expand your knowledge on families from a biblical perspective, please get our free 2025 Resource Book.

Available now in Chinese (Simplified and Traditional), English, French, Italian, Kurundi, Portuguese, Romanian, and Spanish.

Visit: family.adventist.org/2025RB

A note from the Principal Contributor

KAREN HOLFORD



This year, the focus of the week is on discovering **God's Great Gifts**.

We aim to help our family connect with God's overflowing love and recognize His gifts through creation, relationships, and Sabbath. We will explore how God's love flows from His heart to ours and then between us, learning to notice and share His love with others. Through daily worship experiences that engage all our senses—seeing His beauty, hearing birdsong, tasting fruits, and feeling His presence—we will discover that God's love surrounds us constantly, waiting to be noticed and shared.

Karen Holford is the Family, Children's and Women's Ministries Director for the Trans-European Division. She has a professional background in occupational therapy and master's degrees in psychology, Family Therapy and Christian Leadership. She is married to Pastor Bernie Holford, and they live in England. They have three adult children and three grandchildren. She loves to write, walk in English forests, and share God's love.

WHY DO FAMILY WORSHIP?

- It teaches our children and families to worship God
- Places God at the center of our homes
- Bonds our families together
- Protects our children and families
- Establishes spiritual values

UNWRAP THE BLESSINGS OF FAMILY WORSHIP

WHAT IS FAMILY WORSHIP?

WHAT FAMILY WORSHIP **IS:**

- Interactive
- Shared leadership
- Brief and engaging

WHAT FAMILY WORSHIP **IS NOT:**

- A lecture, sermon, or coercive activity
- Time for discipline or punishment
- Entertainment

HOW TO DO FAMILY WORSHIP?

Worship is a time when we give adoration and praise to God. With reverence, humility, and gratitude, we make our requests to him. In the Old Testament, animals were sacrificed on the altars. **Today, we need only a sacrifice of time and self.** When we add the word family to worship, we come together to worship God as a family.

Parents especially get an **opportunity to disciple their children and teach them how to worship God.** Together, we take the time to express honor and respect to God and acknowledge Him as Lord and Savior of our lives and our home. This experience bonds us to one another and draws us closer to God.

Every family can decide how their family worship time looks and what tools they will include. It may consist of reading the bible, singing a song, and praying together as a family. But there are many ways to have family worship as many as there are families. Every family is unique, so you can custom build your family altar just for your family.

The only thing that remains the same is that we should turn our focus toward God, the Creator and Sustainer of humankind.

“

In every family there should be a fixed time for morning and evening worship. How appropriate it is for parents to gather their children about them before the fast is broken, to thank the heavenly Father for His protection during the night, and...when evening comes, to gather once more before Him and thank Him for the blessings of the day past.”

Ellen G. White,
Child Guidance, p. 520

“

There is no reason why [family worship] should not be the most interesting and enjoyable exercise of the home life, and God is dishonored when it is made dry and irksome. Let the seasons of family worship be short and spirited.”

Ellen G. White,
Child Guidance, p. 521

REMEMBER:

Your family worship may not be perfect, and that's okay. Pray to God and keep doing your best; He is with you.



**DAILY
GIFTS:**

FAMILY MOMENTS OF WORSHIP



Building a family altar is one of God's great gifts—a way to celebrate His love, creation, relationships, and Sabbath. Like Israel's loose-rock altars, yours may need rebuilding or a fresh approach when life gets busy. No shame in missing a day—just grace in returning to worship.

Let the **God's Great Gifts** devotional inspire worship through four themes: love, creation's wonder, relationships, and Sabbath rest.

Love:

Share a way you witnessed God's love.

Wonder:

Admire something in nature—perhaps a flower, a bird, or the night sky.

Relationships:

Name a time you felt God's care at home, big or small.

Rest:

Light a candle or play soft music to mark Sabbath renewal.

Customize with a song, skit, or act of simple kindness. Each moment together—no matter how brief—is a divine gift. Keep worship fresh, relevant, and age-appropriate: act out a verse, pray briefly, or sing a short song of praise. Even two minutes of intentional prayer honors God's gifts and strengthens your family altar.



HOW TO **STEPS** USE THIS **TO DAILY** RESOURCE **WORSHIP**

BIBLE VERSE



A Bible verse with a simple, creative activity to help you memorize it and experience it in a practical way.

FOUNDATION

INTRODUCTION



An introduction to the theme of the day and why it is good for us.

SETTING THE MOOD

DEVOTIONAL



A short devotional story designed for the whole family.

CORE MESSAGE

PRAYER



Pray together—where everyone can share their heart's desire.

COMMUNION

ACTIVITIES



Several simple activities to help you practice gratitude for God's gifts in your family life.

REINFORCING

IN A HURRY?

TRY THE **“AT A GLANCE”** SECTION AT THE END OF EVERY DAY OR AT PAGE 48



GOD'S *great gift* OF LOVE

SUNDAY

TODAY'S GIFT

Discover and share
God's boundless,
life-filling love.

MEMORY VERSE

We love Him because
He first loved us.
1 John 4:19 NKJV

MEMORY VERSE ACTIVITIES

Cut out paper hearts or use heart-shaped sticky notes. Write each word of the verse and the Bible reference on separate hearts. Then, arrange them in the correct order.



INTRODUCTION

God's Endless Love

God is pure love. Love flows from His heart to us, and then His love flows between us. We express our love for Him in the ways we love each other and how we serve and worship God. Before the Fall, love was the only operating system in the universe, and when sin is eradicated, love will be the focus of all our relationships forever.

Although the cosmic conflict is currently being fought in the universe, it is not the overarching theme. The Big Picture of the universe is that God is love, and His love will overcome and endure forever. As humans, our awareness of God's magnificent and extravagant love is blurry and limited. But one day, we will see Him face to face. Then, we will spend the rest of eternity discovering new facets of His love that are completely beyond our comprehension as human beings.

In our worship times this week, we will explore some of the dimensions of God's love expressed through His creations, relations (marriage), and celebrations (Sabbath).

DEVOTIONAL

God's Great Gift of Love

Lara rested her head against Daddy's chest. She could hear his heart beating ba-bump...ba-bump...ba-bump... "Daddy," Lara looked at Daddy's smiling face, "What is your heart whispering?"

"My heart is saying that I'm alive! And it says I love you, and I love mommy, and I love Luke!" Daddy kissed his finger and touched the tip of Lara's nose. She giggled.

"Daddy, how does all that love get into your heart?" Lara patted Daddy's chest.

"Well, it happens like this. God is so full of love that we can't imagine how much He loves us! His love is so big that it will take forever for us to learn about it, and we'll never come to the end of discovering His wonderful love!"

Luke tried to imagine the size of God's love. But he couldn't. "Wow! That's a lot of love! I can't even stretch my brain around that!"

"How did God's love get from His heart to your heart?" Lara was still curious.

"Well, when God made Adam and Eve, He loved them very much. He spent time with them, and He listened to them. He made many wonderful things for them to see, and smell and taste and enjoy. God cared for His beloved children, and, as He loved them, He filled their hearts with love. Adam and Eve learned how to love and care for each other. When they had babies, they loved them and filled up their hearts with love too!"

Daddy picked up a pitcher of grape juice. "Imagine that this pitcher is filled with God's love. God pours it into our hearts like this..." He poured the juice into four glasses, one for each of them. "And we pour our love into each other's glasses too. God feels our love. He doesn't need us to fill His heart with love, but He enjoys watching His children care for each other."

Lara and Luke drank some of the grape juice. “MMM, delicious!” Luke tipped his head back to get the last drop.

“It’s so sweet and good!” said Lara, “just like God’s love!”

“God is loving us all the time,” said Mommy. “We can’t always see it, and we can’t always feel it. But if we look very closely and listen very carefully, we can find His love in all kinds of places.”

“Yes! I saw God’s love today when Daddy helped you carry the groceries!” exclaimed Lara.

Luke remembered seeing a bird with wool in her beak. “And I saw God’s love when I watched a bird making a nest for her eggs!”

“And I feel God’s love when we’re all together, having one big hug!” Daddy put his strong arms around everyone, and they laughed as he squeezed them gently.

“God’s love is around us all the time,” said Mommy. We just have to notice it and share it with others.”



PRAYING
TOGETHER

Alphabet Prayer of God’s love

- Go through the alphabet and praise God for His love that is A – Abundant, Amazing; B – Blessing, Bountiful; C – Caring, Close...find at least one word for each letter.
- Or fill a small cloth bag with alphabet letters or write each letter on a small card. Take turns to choose a letter and roll a dice to find a number. Then find 5 things or words to describe God’s love beginning with M; or 3 words beginning with R, etc.

MAKING MEMORIES



Family Activities



God's Gift of Love

- Wrap a cardboard box in plain paper like a present.
- Tie a pretty bow around it.
- Talk about how God loves us (Provider, Forgiver, Father, etc.).
- On the wrapped box, write each way God shows love and draw a heart around it until the box is full.
- For ideas, read Psalms 23, 103, 145; 1 Corinthians 13; and 1 John 4.



God's Love Scavenger Hunt

- Have each family member find three items that remind them of God's love.
- Display the items on a tray and let everyone explain their choices.
- Arrange the items in a heart shape, photograph from above, and turn it into a poster.
- Keep adding new items to the display throughout the week.
- Alternative: Fill a wide-mouth jar with 20 love reminders and cover them with rice or millet. Seal it, then rotate or shake the jar to uncover each item.



Arty Heart

- Cut a heart shape from cardstock or scrap cardboard.
- Find pictures and words in magazines that show God's love.
- Arrange them on your heart, adding your own artwork and other reminders of His love.
- Once you're happy with the design, glue everything down and hang it up.

SUNDAY AT A GLANCE

THE VERSE

We love Him because
He first loved us.
1 John 4:19 NKJV

THE INTRODUCTION

God's never-ending love
fills and flows through us.

THE DEVOTIONAL

Daddy used grape juice
to show how God pours
His love into our hearts—
and how we pour it
into others.

THE PRAYER

Thank You, Lord, for
pouring Your love into
my life.

THE CONVERSATION

Where did you notice
God's love today, and
how will you share it with
someone else?

**GOD
STARTS**
to make our
WORLD

MONDAY

TODAY'S GIFT

Marvel at God's
creation of light, water,
land, and plants.

MEMORY VERSE

In the beginning God
created the heavens and
the earth. Gen 1:1 NKJV

MEMORY VERSE ACTIVITIES

Read each phrase slowly and add a simple gesture—"In the beginning..." (one finger up), "God..." (point to the sky), "created..." (hands molding), "the heavens..." (arm sweeping overhead), "and the earth..." (finger tracing the ground). Pause after each, let your children echo, then move on.



INTRODUCTION

The Wonder of Creation

The story of creation is packed with wonder and current research affirms the power of wonder. Wonder reduces our anxiety and helps us to feel peaceful, joyful, and grateful. When we experience wonder we think more creatively and show greater kindness to others. Most of all, when we look at the amazing works of God's creation, even our own hands, we have glimpses into His character of love, wisdom, creativity, and artistry.

Pause to have a slow moment of wonder with your family today. Look at your fruit and vegetables. Cut them open and appreciate the beauty of their design. Smell their fragrance, feel their textures, taste their flavors. Explore the details of a flower or leaf. Watch a bird or insect as it moves. Everything has been designed by God.

During the Sermon on the Mount, Jesus told His friends not to worry about clothes and food but to look at the flowers and birds that God has made and know that He is taking good care of us. Wonder opens the hearts of our children to God's love and helps them fall in love with Him forever. Sometimes, wonder is more powerful than a sermon in leading people to His love.

DEVOTIONAL

God Starts to Make our World

Find a candle and matches, or a flashlight; a bottle of water and glasses and some blowing bubbles; some fruits or flowers.

God's heart was overflowing with love and delight as He worked out His design for a beautiful new planet. He loved Adam and Eve already, even though He hadn't created them yet. God imagined His brand-new children living in a perfect garden filled with everything they could ever want. He chose the perfect planet. It was empty, bare, and ready for Him to fill with beautiful things!

On the first day, God visited the planet called Earth. It was very dark. So He created pure light to brighten the darkness. The

light shone like gold on the bare earth as it waited to be filled with God's wonderful creations. The light shone until nighttime, and then it was dark again. His children would enjoy seeing the beautiful light. God looked at everything He had made in love and saw that it was good.

Let's light this candle or turn on this flashlight to remind us that God created all the light we can see. **(Invite children to light the candle or flashlight.)**

On the second day, God visited the planet again. The light shone brightly as God arranged the water on the earth and made a huge bubble of water around the planet to keep it watered. The pure water sparkled in the light, and everything looked clean and fresh. His children would enjoy drinking the clear water, splashing in the rivers, and seeing the blue sky. God looked at everything He had made in love, and He saw that it was good. **(Let children drink the pure water and blow bubbles.)**

On the third day, God visited planet Earth again. This was going to be an amazing day! There was so much to do! He shaped

the earth with hills and valleys. He drew the coastline in the ocean sands. Then He covered all the earth with green and growing things. Soft, sweet grass to walk on, flowers to fragrance the air, delicious juicy fruits, and tasty nuts to eat. Tall trees, short trees, bushes, different leaves, textures, and tastes. He planted a special garden where His beloved children would live and where He would meet them every day.

They would enjoy walking on the grass, smelling the perfumed flowers, and eating

the delicious things that grew on the ground, in the bushes, and in the trees—especially the juicy, sticky mangoes! God looked at everything He had made in love, and He saw that it was good. **(Let the children look at the flowers with wonder and share the fruit with them.)**

God took great care of the new planet and everything He had made. He wanted Adam and Eve to live in a beautiful place so that everything would remind them of His great love for them.



PRAYING
TOGETHER

The Bowl of Creation Prayer

- Take a large bowl to show the empty earth.
- Place a floatable candle in the bowl (fix a small candle to a piece of wood or cork that will float. Light the candle (Day 1).
- Pour water into the bowl (Day 2).
- Add a few flowers, leaves, or other vegetation to the bowl to make a pretty feature (Day 3).
- Pray, thanking God for all kinds of lights that help us (candles, car lights, flashlights, etc.), all kinds of water features in the world (rivers, waterfalls, streams, lakes, etc.), and all kinds of flowers, fruit, trees and vegetables.

MAKING MEMORIES



Family Activities



Filled with Wonder

- Gather small treasures from nature (shells, leaves, flowers, fruit skins, feathers, etc.).
- Pick one item and study it quietly for one minute.
- Share with the family what amazed you about that creation.



Scrap Creations

- Collect clean paper scraps (magazines, newspapers, wrappers).
- Use scissors and glue to craft a paper flower, fruit, or vegetable.
- Compare your paper design to the real thing and talk about what you discovered.



Fruit Salad

- Have each person choose a favorite fruit.
- Observe its outside, then slice it open to admire the inside.
- Combine the pieces into a fruit salad (or arrange slices on plates).
- Thank God for every juicy, delicious flavor.



Beautify Your Home

- Brainstorm ways to make your home more beautiful (tidy, rearrange, display flowers).
- Use materials you already have to create a decoration.
- Hang a decorated heart or a favorite Bible verse where everyone can see it.

MONDAY AT A GLANCE

THE VERSE

In the beginning God created the heavens and the earth. Gen 1:1 NKJV

THE INTRODUCTION

God's artistry shines in light, water, and plants.

THE DEVOTIONAL

Day 1: light; Day 2: water; Day 3: plants—each showing His love and care.

THE PRAYER

Thank You, Lord, for light that leads us, water that refreshes us, and plants that nourish us.

THE CONVERSATION

Which creation—light, water, or plants—speaks most of God's love to you?



GOD CONTINUES *to create our* WORLD

TUESDAY

TODAY'S GIFT

Celebrating
God's creativity
as He fills water
and sky with life.

MEMORY VERSE

Then God said, "Let the waters abound
with an abundance of living creatures,
and let birds fly above the earth
across the face of the firmament
of the heavens." Gen 1:20 NKJV

MEMORY VERSE ACTIVITIES

Draw a simple picture with water below and sky above. In the water, write the first part of the verse, drawing a fish around each word. In the sky, write the second part and draw a bird beside each word. Then decorate your picture to show God's beautiful creation.

INTRODUCTION

Multisensory Worship and Learning

God created us with five extraordinary senses to experience the delights of His creation. Our eyes look for wonders and beauty all around us. Our ears hear birdsong, animal sounds, conversations, and music. Our tongues taste the fruits, vegetables, and nuts that God created with all kinds of textures and flavors. Our noses smell the fragrance of flowers and good food, and our hands feel the different textures of animal furs, the bark of trees, and other wonderful things. In a broken world, these senses help keep us safe. We use all our senses to recognize dangers, too.

Our senses are important because they help us to explore God's world and to see that it is good. God designed the Tabernacle service and the feasts of His people to involve all the senses because they help us to worship God and learn about Him. Every time you use multisensory experiences to teach your children about God's love, you are helping them to learn, to understand, and to remember God's love in important ways, with their whole body. So be creative, like God, and engage all your senses in learning about Him every day.

DEVOTIONAL

God Continues to Create Our World

God visited the new world on day four. Light sparkled on the water. Flowers, trees, and grass covered the earth and the hills with wonderful colors. Everything looked beautiful and peaceful. Today God wanted to make special lights for the sky. The light was good. But God added the sun to warm the earth, to help things grow, and to paint sunsets and sunrises that swirled with color. God filled the night sky with billions of stars and planets to light up the darkness and inspire hearts with wonder. He made a moon to shine in the night and to change shape in ways that measured weeks and months. God felt the warm sun

on His face. And as the sun slipped over the horizon in a blaze of color, the moon and stars sparkled in the dark sky. At the end of the day, God looked at all He had made, and He saw that it was good. **(Look outside to notice the sunlight, shadows, moon, and stars.)**

On day five, the sun rose and tinted the sky pink and yellow. God watched the beauty of the dawn and looked at the sunlight glimmering on the water. It was clear and still. He thought of all the fish he had created and suddenly the water was splashing and sparkling with thousands of colorful fish and sea creatures. Dolphins jumped over waves, whales spouted water, and tiny fish darted among the rocks and shells. God looked at all the fish and sea creatures in the oceans, lakes and rivers, and He saw that it was good. **(Can you name a fish or sea creature that begins with the same letter as your name?)**

The God looked up into the sky. The world was quiet, and the sky was still. God thought of all the birds He had imagined. Suddenly, the music of a thousand birds filled the sky. Swallows soared in the

sunlight. Eagles hovered over the earth. Peacocks fanned their gorgeous jewel-colored tails, and tiny hummingbirds drank nectar from the flowers. Now the sky was filled with joyful birds, swirling and gliding on feathered wings, and their songs brightened the world with soft, sweet sounds. And God sat and listened and watched, and He saw that it was good. **(Make the sound of your favorite birds and sing their songs together. How does it sound?)**

On the sixth day, God watched the sun rise again. He thought of all the creatures He would make, and they started to appear. Tiny mice, tall giraffes, heavy elephants, nimble squirrels, cuddly cats, and fluffy sheep...So many animals! They ran and hopped and climbed and crept! So many different shapes and colors and furs and tails! God loves variety! And then God saw that everything was ready to welcome His special children. He would make them next. His heart was filled with love and joy at the thought of creating Adam and Eve. He smiled. Soon they would see His face and feel His love.



PRAYING
TOGETHER
**Gratitude
Prayer**

- Thank God for making fish, birds, and animals
- Say, "Thank You God for making the creatures that swim in the ocean, such as whales". The next person will repeat that sentence and add another sea creature: "such as whales and jellyfish." The third person will add another: "such as whales, jellyfish and angel fish".



Family Activities



Find the Creatures!

- Choose a landscape picture with sky, land, and water (from a calendar, magazine, or your own photo). Gather scissors, white paper, glue, and art supplies.
- Parents: Cut small flaps (about 1 inch or 2.5 cm) in the sky, land, and water areas to make little doors.
- Fold the flaps open and glue the landscape onto the white paper.
- Let children draw birds behind sky flaps, animals behind land flaps, and fish behind water flaps.
- Pause to enjoy God's amazing creatures. (Matthew 6:26–30)



Bird Mobile

- Gather cardstock, art materials, scissors, needle, thread, and a stick, branch, or hanger.
- Draw bird shapes, decorate with colors, feathers, or paper wings and curls.
- On each bird, write a short prayer or praise for God's birds.
- Thread and hang the birds at different heights on your branch or hanger.
- Display your mobile as a reminder to thank God for birds and their songs.



Amazing Animals!

- Take turns acting like animals—move and make their sounds.
- Let others guess the animal.
- Thank God for something special about it.
- Then let the next person try!

TUESDAY AT A GLANCE

THE VERSE

Then God said, "Let the waters abound with an abundance of living creatures, and let birds fly above the earth across the face of the firmament of the heavens." Gen 1:20 NKJV

THE INTRODUCTION

God gave us senses to enjoy His love through sights, sounds, and textures.

THE DEVOTIONAL

God filled the sky with birds and the water with sea creatures—each showing His creativity.

THE PRAYER

Thank You, Lord, for birds, fish, and animals that remind us of You.

THE CONVERSATION

Which creature shows God's creativity to you?

GOD'S
great gift of
MARRIAGE

WEDNESDAY

TODAY'S GIFT

Celebrating
God's beautiful
design for love
and marriage.

MEMORY VERSE

And the Lord God said, "It is
not good that man should be
alone; I will make him a helper
comparable to him." Gen 2:18 NKJV

INTRODUCTION

God's Plan for Marriage

MEMORY VERSE ACTIVITIES

Cut two simple paper shapes of a man and a woman. Write the first sentence of the text on the man and the second sentence on the woman. Stick their hands together so that they are holding hands. Then read out the words.

God made the whole world for His beloved children. He planted Eden to be their special home. Everything He had made was designed to express His love for them and His wonderfully creative, kind, and generous character. He created Adam and Eve to be equals in marriage because He knew that any imbalance of power in a relationship can cause pain and resentment and even abuse and distress. God created Eve to be Adam's equal and companion.

When sin entered the world, the man's work of caring for the ground became much harder, and the woman's work of giving birth became more painful. During Jesus' ministry, He cared for women who were widows, foreigners, and in complicated relationships, and He lifted them up by healing them, forgiving them, restoring them, and ministering to them. Paul tells husbands and wives to submit mutually to each other (Eph 5:21). Throughout Paul's epistles, he describes practical ways that Christians can love one another and show mutual care for each other, especially in Romans 12:9-18. God intends marriage to be a place of mutual love, compassion, support, and joy, just as He created it to be.

DEVOTIONAL

God's Great Gift of Marriage

God's heart was overflowing with joyful love as He looked at the blue sky and sparkling water. He saw thousands of flowers in the grass and the shade of hundreds of trees. He felt the warmth of the sun on His back. And he smiled at the fish in the water, the birds in the sky, and the animals playing in the sunlight, completely unafraid of each other. A lion was gently licking a lamb, and a squirrel ran along the back of an elephant. Butterflies danced among the flowers and monkeys pulled fruit from the trees. The garden was the perfect home for his new children.

God crouched down on the ground and began to make the shape of a man out of the damp clay. He would be called

Adam. When the sculpture was finished, God breathed into Adam's mouth, and he came to life. He opened his eyes and saw God smiling at him. Then he stood up and looked around. Everything was perfectly wonderful. God handed him some fruit and told him to taste it. Mmmm! Delicious! And then they went for a walk together. God showed Adam other juicy fruits and nuts to eat. He showed him the flowers, and he sniffed the fragrance. They listened to the birds, and they met the animals. God brought the animals to Adam in pairs. He saw that the two animals looked similar but were also slightly different. God explained that one of the pairs was a male, like Adam, and the other was a female. Together, they would make more animals just like them. Adam named all the animals. It was fun to see all the different creatures God had made so perfectly.

Adam asked God why he didn't have a partner too. God made Adam fall asleep. He carefully took a rib from his body and healed up the space. Then He took the bone and flesh and shaped it into a beautiful woman. She had bright eyes

and beautiful hair, and God smiled as He took her by the hand and helped her to stand. Then Adam woke up. When he saw Eve, he was so happy! He knew that she had come from his own body and God had made her, especially for him. Wow! Eve was far more beautiful than any other creature in the garden!

They held each other's hands and smiled at each other. A huge wave of love flowed through their hearts. God smiled and blessed them. "Love each other and look after each other! I love you and I made this beautiful garden for you to live in!

Enjoy each other, enjoy the garden! Have babies, love them like I love you, and make a family together!"

They spent the rest of the day together, tasting different fruits, and watching the playful animals. They stood with God and watched the wonderful sunset. God felt very happy. Now everything He had made was not just good...It was very good. God hugged His precious children goodnight and promised to return in the morning with a special surprise. Adam and Eve found a warm place to fall asleep in each other's arms. It was good to be alive!



PRAYING
TOGETHER

Marriage Blessing

- Find your own wedding photo or the photo of a married couple in your family. Place it on a sheet of paper and write a prayer or a blessing around it. Phil 1:9-11 or Num 6:24-26. Send a photograph of the photo and blessing to the couple. Or display it in your home if it is your photo.

MAKING MEMORIES



Family Activities



Sculpt a Person

- Use playdough, clay, or salt dough to shape a person.
- Let everyone try making their own.
- Talk about how hard it is to make a person.
- Thank God for creating each of us so beautifully.



Edible Family

- Make cookie-dough people, buy gingerbread cookies, or cut people shapes from bread.
- Create one edible person for each family member.
- Decorate them using raisins, frosting, or fruit.
- Take a fun photo before eating your edible family!



Make a Wedding

- Gather clothes, bed sheets, or curtains to create wedding outfits.
- Dress one child as a bride and another as a groom.
- If not possible, lay two outfits on the floor.
- Make a simple bouquet from flowers, paper, or drawings.
- Hold a pretend wedding with songs, a Bible verse, and a prayer.



Design a Garden Home

- Imagine how Adam and Eve lived in the Garden of Eden.
- Use paper, boxes, or craft supplies to design a garden home.
- Work together or make individual designs.
- Share your creations and thank God for nature.

WEDNESDAY AT A GLANCE

THE VERSE

And the Lord God said, "It is not good that man should be alone; I will make him a helper comparable to him."

Gen 2:18 NKJV

THE INTRODUCTION

God created marriage as a loving partnership built on care and equality.

THE DEVOTIONAL

In Eden, God formed Adam and Eve for each other and blessed them with love and joy.

THE PRAYER

Thank You, Lord, for marriage and for giving us love and companionship.

THE CONVERSATION

What makes a marriage loving and strong?



THE GREAT *Gift of Loving* FAMILIES

THURSDAY

TODAY'S GIFT

Learning, sharing,
and growing love in
our family every day.

MEMORY VERSE

Be kindly affectionate to one
another with brotherly love,
in honor giving preference to
one another; Rom 12:10 NKJV

MEMORY VERSE ACTIVITIES

Hold hands in a circle and say one word of the verse in turn until you have completed the verse.

Say it a few times until you all know it by heart. Then, give each other a big hug.

INTRODUCTION

The Importance of Love

While not every couple has children, God designed marriage to create safe, loving homes where children can grow and feel loved. Children thrive in families filled with affection, encouragement, comfort, and security. When babies and toddlers receive consistent love and care, they develop a healthy sense of identity and build strong brains prepared for empathy and compassion.

Sadly, children who face neglect, abuse, or are left to cry without comfort may suffer long-term effects. Trauma in early years can limit brain connections needed for emotional health and caring for others.

These children often struggle with relationships, confidence, and both physical and mental well-being later in life.

God's plan was for marriages and families to be daily places of love, safety, and joy—a reflection of His love for us. As parents, caregivers, or family members, we can help build that environment.

What can you do this week to show God's love to your family?

DEVOTIONAL

The Great Gift of Loving Families

“Wow! It would have been amazing to watch God make our world!” Luke exclaimed. “Yes!” said Lara. “I would love to see God putting stars in the sky!”

“I’d like to help Adam name the animals!” laughed Luke. “Some of them are pretty funny!” Daddy smiled. “I’d love to watch God making Adam and Eve and see how He welcomed them into their new world.”

“I wish I could have seen Adam and Eve meeting for the first time!” said Mommy, giving Daddy a playful wink. “Do you remember when we first met?” “How

could I ever forget?” Daddy grinned and kissed Mommy on the cheek. “I’m so glad we fell in love... that you married me... and I’m super glad you two were born into our family!”

“Families are God’s way of sharing His love,” said Mommy. “God showed Adam and Eve what love was like. Then He told them to have a family and pass that love from parent to child.” “But sin came into the world,” Daddy added, “and people started hurting each other instead of loving each other. That’s why Jesus came—to show us how to love God and love others.”

“OK,” said Mommy, smiling. “I have a fun idea! Luke and Lara, how do you know that Daddy and I love each other? What do we do that shows our love?” Luke and Lara looked at each other and began to think. “You hug each other a lot!” said Luke. “You say thank you to each other!” added Lara. “Daddy forgave Mommy when she bumped the car a little bit!” said Luke with a grin. “And Mommy forgave Daddy when he dropped her vase!” giggled Lara. “You help each other without being asked,” said Luke. “And you say sorry when you hurt

each other, or make a mistake, or forget to do something,” added Lara thoughtfully.

“Yes!” Daddy said. “Every day, we try to do kind things for each other. It makes us both happy when we’re kind, helpful, and thankful.” “I feel safe and happy when I see you loving each other,” whispered Lara. “Me too!” agreed Luke.

“So, how about you two?” asked Mommy. “How do you love each other?” Luke and Lara grew quiet. They knew they sometimes annoyed each other. “We share our toys,” said Luke. “Well... sometimes we do.” “Sometimes we help each other tidy

our room,” said Lara. “I guess we could do more of that.”

Mommy smiled. “We feel happy when you’re kind to each other.” “This week I heard Lara thank Luke for carrying her heavy bag,” said Daddy. “And Luke encouraged Lara when she was doing her homework.”

“Well, we’re learning from you and Mommy how to love,” said Luke, “and I guess you learned it from God!” “We sure did!” laughed Daddy. “And from our own families. Even though no family is perfect, the more we love each other, the more we become like Jesus.”



PRAYING
TOGETHER

Wrapped in Love Prayer

- Hold hands in a circle and take turns to pray loving prayers for the person on your left.
- When everyone has prayed, pray in turn for the person on your right.
- Everyone will have been prayed for twice.
- If anyone feels too shy to pray, they can pray silently and squeeze the hand of the next person when they have finished.
- Finish with a group hug.

MAKING MEMORIES



Family Activities



Love Notes

- Cut paper hearts or make small cards.
- Write a short love note for each family member.



Love List

- Make a list of ways to show love at home.
- Ask everyone their favorite way to feel loved.
- Choose one thing each day to show love to every person.



Love Garland

- Cut out hand-sized hearts from construction paper.
- Find Bible verses about love (like Romans 12:9–18 or 1 Corinthians 13).
- Write one verse on each heart and decorate them.
- Connect the hearts to make a garland and hang it at home.



Memorize Together

- Pick an easy-to-understand Bible version.
- Copy Romans 12:9–18 and learn one verse each week as a family.
- Talk about how to live out each verse at home.



Many Kinds of Love!

- Gather craft supplies.
- Let each person choose a love theme (kindness, patience, encouragement, etc.).
- Create a heart showing that kind of love.
- Display your creations as a family reminder.

THURSDAY AT A GLANCE

THE VERSE

Be kindly affectionate to one another with brotherly love, in honor giving preference to one another;
Rom 12:10 NKJV

THE INTRODUCTION

God calls us to love each other with kind words and caring actions.

THE DEVOTIONAL

Through notes, lists, decorations, and Bible verses, we celebrate love in simple, everyday ways.

THE PRAYER

Thank You, Lord, for showing us how to love through kindness.

THE CONVERSATION

What's one way you'll show love today?



FRIDAY

TODAY'S GIFT

Celebrate the Sabbath—a weekly gift from God filled with love, rest, joy, and time together.

MEMORY VERSE

Then God blessed the seventh day and sanctified it, because in it He rested from all His work which God had created and made. Gen 2:3 NKJV

INTRODUCTION

MEMORY VERSE ACTIVITIES

Draw a large number 7 on a sheet of paper. Write the first part of the sentence along the top of the 7 and the second half of the sentence down the stem of the 7. Then, cover the words and say them from memory.



Sabbath: A Gift of Love

Sabbath is a gift of love from God to care for our spiritual, physical, emotional, and relational well-being. He knows we need to pause from our weekly routines and focus on His love. In His loving arms, we can reflect on the past week and notice how He has led us and loved us. We can pray about the week to come, give Him our worries and fears, and pray for the love and wisdom to help us through our challenges.

Sabbath is a day to care for our bodies, to rest from hard work, or to walk in nature if we have been sitting inside all week. It's a day to experience the positive emotions of heaven as we worship God: joy, love, peace, wonder, hope, inspiration, a sense of purpose, creativity, gratitude, and laughter. And it's a day to show love to others and alleviate their suffering. How will you share these beautiful gifts with your family?

DEVOTIONAL

God's Great Gift of Sabbath

It was Friday evening, and Daddy was ready to start worship. He had blown up a whole bag of balloons. There were two big red heart-shaped balloons and lots of other round balloons. Luke and Lara wondered what he would do with all the balloons in worship!

Daddy asked Luke and Lara to name all the activities that happened during the week: school, shopping, football, work, laundry, making dinner, cleaning, gardening, homework, going to work! The list was long. Each time they called out a word, Daddy wrote it on a different balloon with a permanent pen.

Soon, all the round balloons had big words written on them. "What about the heart-shaped balloons?" asked Lara. "What are

they for?" Daddy wrote "Loving God" on one heart-shaped balloon and "Loving other people" on the other balloon.

Lara and Luke stood in the middle of the room. Daddy said, "Now, you must work hard to keep all the balloons up in the air at once, and none of them are allowed to touch the floor!"

Luke and Lara started throwing the balloons in the air. There were so many balloons, and it was hard to stop them from falling on the floor. They ran around, hitting the balloons in the air as fast as possible. It was hard work, and soon, they were tired.

"Well done, Lara and Luke!" said Mommy. "It's hard work keeping all the balloons in the air! Working all week long is exhausting!"

"Now it's Sabbath!" said daddy. "You can let all the 'work' balloons drop on the floor and have a rest." Mommy gathered them up in a big garbage bag. The heart-shaped balloons were left on the floor. "Now just keep these two in the air."

Lara and Luke gently patted the two balloons. Keeping the two “love” balloons in the air was so restful and easy. Each time they tapped a balloon, they called out for kind and loving things to do on Sabbath.

“When Adam and Eve woke up after their first night’s sleep, God had a special gift waiting for the world! Can you guess what it was?”

“Was it the continuation of Sabbath?” wondered Luke. “Yes! Sabbath is like an every-week birthday gift for the world! It’s a love gift from God from sunset Friday to sunset Saturday!” Mommy smiled.

“God wasn’t tired, and Adam and Eve hadn’t worked at all. But God wanted them to have the special gift one day every week to spend with Him, learning about love and creation, and caring for each other,” explained Daddy.

Mommy handed Luke and Lara a big gift box. “Here’s a present to remind you of the special gifts that God packed into Sabbath for us to enjoy.” Inside was a beautiful Bible storybook, a backpack of things for exploring nature, beautiful cards to take to lonely people and others in need, and a fun Bible game to play together. They smiled. Sabbath was a wonderful every-week birthday gift for the world!



PRAYING TOGETHER **Sabbath Blessing**

- In some Jewish traditions, each family lights candles on Friday evenings and prays blessings over each other.
- Gather one candle for each person in the family. Light the candles safely.
- Tell each person in your family one way in which they have blessed you in the past week.
- Pray a blessing over each person and ask God to bless their Sabbath rest with love, peace, and joy.

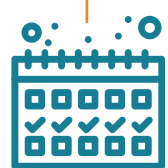


Family Activities



Sabbath Gifts

- Find a small gift box or container.
- Have each person choose three small items that remind them of the Sabbath. Ideas: a battery (Sabbath recharges us), a heart (God's love), hand lotion (comfort), a seed (new beginnings), or a treat (joy).
- Put all the items in the box and talk about why each was chosen.
- Place the box on your table as a Sabbath reminder.



Seven Days in a Row

- Look around your home for seven objects that represent something from each day of the past week.
- Pick one item for Sunday through Friday and something special for Sabbath.
- Line them up in order to tell your week's story.
- Share how you saw God's love each day.



Sabbath Manna

- Gather paper plates (or cut paper circles), pens, and snacks like popcorn, nuts, or dried fruit.
- Read Exodus 16:1–31 about manna.
- Divide the plate into seven sections, one for each day.
- Place one snack for Sunday through Thursday, two for Friday, none for Sabbath.
- Act out each day by eating, moving, then resting. On Sabbath, eat Friday's extra portion and sing a praise song!

FRIDAY AT A GLANCE

THE VERSE

Then God blessed the seventh day and sanctified it, because in it He rested from all His work which God had created and made. Gen 2:3 NKJV

THE INTRODUCTION

Sabbath is God's special gift for rest, joy, and love.

THE DEVOTIONAL

God invites us to pause from work, enjoy His creation, and focus on loving Him and others.

THE PRAYER

Thank You, Lord, for the Sabbath—a day to rest and love.

THE CONVERSATION

How will you celebrate God's Sabbath gift this week?

SABBATH

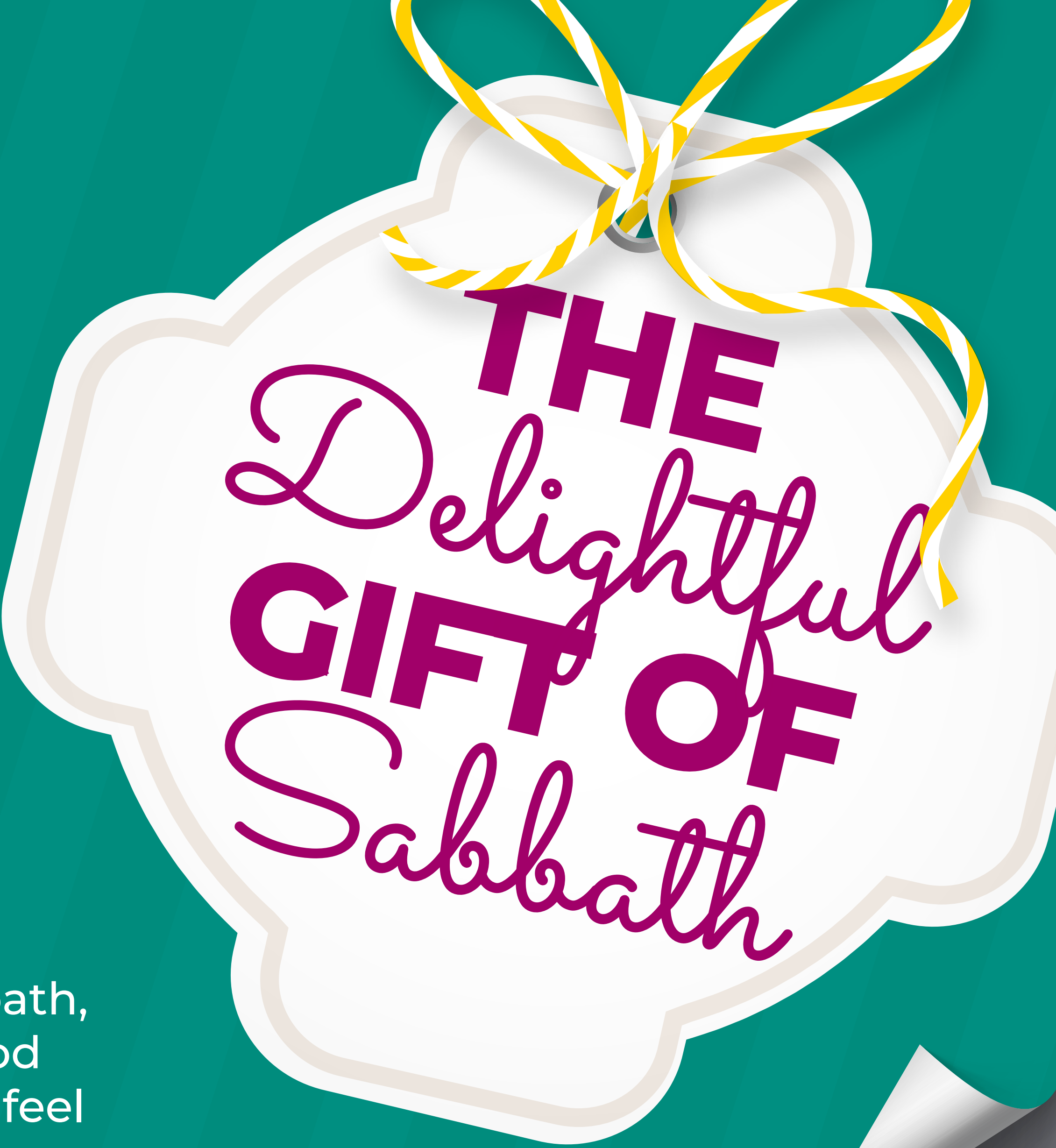
MEMORY VERSE

“If you turn away
your foot from
the Sabbath,
From doing your
pleasure on My
holy day, And
call the Sabbath
a delight,...Then
you shall delight
yourself in the
Lord;...”

Isa 58:13, 14 NKJV

TODAY'S GIFT

Delight in the Sabbath,
a joyful gift from God
to rest, rejoice, and feel
His love.



THE
Delightful
GIFT OF
Sabbath

MEMORY VERSE ACTIVITIES

Say this verse together, clapping your hands in a joyful rhythm that matches the sounds.

INTRODUCTION

Day of Delight

God intends Sabbath to be a day of delight for us, the best day of the week! Although we choose not to work and do business on the Sabbath, God intends for us to experience the positive blessings of delight, wonder, inspiration, love and joy. One of the best ways to pass on the importance of the Sabbath to our children is to ensure that the Sabbath is the happiest and most delightful day of their week.

Delight is different for every person because God has made us unique. Some delight in being outside in nature. Some enjoy using their creative skills to bless others. Some like to care for those in need. Others enjoy singing and being musical or discussing the Bible together. What delights your children? What do they enjoy doing on Sabbath? How can you help them enjoy their time in church? What are their favorite Sabbath foods? Once you discover their delights, look for wonderful ways to help them to experience delight on Sabbath.

The Gift of a Delight Day

Luke, Lara, Mommy, and Daddy sat by a lake eating their Sabbath picnic lunch.

“I wonder what God did with Adam and Eve on their very first Sabbath?” asked Lara. “They didn’t go to church!”

“They probably had a picnic by a lake, just like us!” laughed Luke. “I think God picked His favorite fruits, and they ate them all up and it was delicious! And then they washed their hands in the lake!”

“The Bible doesn’t tell us what happened, but it would have been a very special day. Imagine waking up with a brand-new world to explore!” Daddy took out his binoculars and looked across the lake for birds.

“I think God sat next to them as they slept, waiting for them to wake up. Because they didn’t know anything about their new home. And He wanted to help them explore it,” imagined Mommy. “Maybe He woke them up to watch the sunrise together, to show them how beautiful it was.”

“I’m sure they listened to the dawn chorus, too!” said Daddy, watching a bird diving into the water to catch a fish.

“God would have explained who He was, and why He had made the garden for them, and how much He loved them,” said Mommy, “because they had no idea why they were there.”

“It would have been a fun day! Watching the sunrise colors, hearing the birds, playing with the animals, listening to God, tasting juicy fruit, and splashing in the water!” Luke tossed a small stone into the lake.

“I know what we can do! Let’s look for things in the woods and make scenes on the sand for each day of creation!” Lara found a bag to collect things in.

The children looked for feathers, flowers, leaves, and stones to make their pictures. Daddy stayed with the picnic and watched the swallows high in the sky.

Their creation pictures looked beautiful on the sand. Lara used a bright yellow flower for the sun. Luke found a few feathers to make a picture of a bird. Daddy shaped Adam in the sand. Mommy laid white stones on a blackened piece of wood to show the creation of light.

“What pictures shall we make for Sabbath?” asked Lara. “Let’s draw a big box in the sand and fill it with lots of hearts to show God’s love!” Luke ran to a nearby bush.

“These red leaves are heart-shaped! We can use them!” They stood back to admire their pictures, and Daddy photographed them all.

“This has been a very special week,” said Lara. “We’ve learned amazing things about God’s love, the wonderful world He made for us, the precious love of our family, and the every-week birthday gift of Sabbath!”

“Wow!” Luke smiled as the sun began to set over the lake. “How wonderful to know we have such a kind, loving, creative and generous God!” “Yes,” said Daddy as he gathered everyone into a big hug. “We are so blessed.”



PRAYING
TOGETHER

Acrostic Sabbath Prayer

Say a special prayer using words that start with each letter of the word Sabbath. Here’s an example:

We praise You, God, for Sabbath—a day that is Soothing and Serene, Amazing and Anxiety-reducing, a Beautiful Blessing, and the Best Breathing Space. Thank You that the Sabbath is Awesome and Abundant, giving us a Tranquil Time Together and a Holy, Happy, and Healthy day. Amen.

MAKING MEMORIES



Family Activities



Best Sabbath Ever Awards

- Make a fun certificate or craft a simple trophy.
- Think about the best Sabbath you've ever had.
- Where were you? Who was with you? What made it special?
- How did this Sabbath help you feel God's love?
- How could you plan another Sabbath like it?
- Share your awards with each other.
- For younger kids, write "Sabbath" on a paper and let them decorate it however they like.



Day of Delight!

- As a family, make a list of 100 simple things you enjoy on Sabbath.
- Write each one on a notebook page or index card.
- Include things like: worship activities, ways to help others, Sabbath walks, favorite songs, Bible stories, special foods, fun games, and places to visit.
- Each week, choose a card and enjoy that activity on Sabbath.



Delightful Sabbath Reminder

- Use craft supplies, paper, and natural items like shells or dried flowers to create something that reminds your family to plan joyful Sabbaths.



Thank You for Sabbath

- Make a thank-you card for God.
- Inside, list all the things you love about Sabbath.

SABBATH AT A GLANCE

THE VERSE

"If you turn away your foot from the Sabbath, From doing your pleasure on My holy day, And call the Sabbath a delight,...Then you shall delight yourself in the Lord;..." Isa 58:13, 14 NKJV

THE INTRODUCTION

Sabbath is God's weekly gift of joy, rest, and love.

THE DEVOTIONAL

God invites us to make Sabbath a day of delight—celebrating His love, creation, and family blessings.

THE PRAYER

Thank You, Lord, for giving us the joyful gift of Sabbath.

THE CONVERSATION

What is one way you'll make this Sabbath delightful?

GOD'S *great* GIFTS

In the beginning, God's heart overflowed with love. That love reached its highest expression in three special gifts that crowned His creation: marriage, family, and the Sabbath. While the first six days show God's power in shaping the physical world, these three gifts reveal His heart and His deepest desires for humanity.

Marriage, family, and Sabbath meet our deepest needs: companionship, belonging, and connection with our Creator. Together, they form a trinity of blessings that continue to nurture and sustain us today. They remind us that we are fearfully and wonderfully made and deeply loved by God (Psalm 139:14).

SUNDAY AT A GLANCE

THE VERSE

We love Him because
He first loved us.
1 John 4:19 NKJV

THE INTRODUCTION

God's never-ending
love fills and flows
through us.

THE DEVOTIONAL

Daddy used grape
juice to show how God
pours His love into our
hearts—and how we
pour it into others.

THE PRAYER

Thank You, Lord, for
pouring Your love into
my life.

THE CONVERSATION

Where did you notice
God's love today, and
how will you share it
with someone else?

MONDAY AT A GLANCE

THE VERSE

In the beginning God
created the heavens
and the earth.
Gen 1:1 NKJV

THE INTRODUCTION

God's artistry shines in
light, water, and plants.

THE DEVOTIONAL

Day 1: light; Day 2: water;
Day 3: plants—each
showing His love and
care.

THE PRAYER

Thank You, Lord, for
light that leads us, water
that refreshes us, and
plants that nourish us.

THE CONVERSATION

Which creation—light,
water, or plants—speaks
most of God's love
to you?

TUESDAY AT A GLANCE

THE VERSE

Then God said, "Let
the waters abound
with an abundance of
living creatures, and
let birds fly above the
earth across the face of
the firmament of the
heavens." Gen 1:20 NKJV

THE INTRODUCTION

God gave us senses to
enjoy His love through
sights, sounds, and
textures.

THE DEVOTIONAL

God filled the sky with
birds and the water with
sea creatures—each
showing His creativity.

THE PRAYER

Thank You, Lord, for
birds, fish, and animals
that remind us of You.

THE CONVERSATION

Which creature shows
God's creativity
to you?

WEDNESDAY AT A GLANCE

THE VERSE

And the Lord God said, "It is not good that man should be alone; I will make him a helper comparable to him." Gen 2:18 NKJV

THE INTRODUCTION

God created marriage as a loving partnership built on care and equality.

THE DEVOTIONAL

In Eden, God formed Adam and Eve for each other and blessed them with love and joy.

THE PRAYER

Thank You, Lord, for marriage and for giving us love and companionship.

THE CONVERSATION

What makes a marriage loving and strong?

THURSDAY AT A GLANCE

THE VERSE

Be kindly affectionate to one another with brotherly love, in honor giving preference to one another;
Rom 12:10 NKJV

THE INTRODUCTION

God calls us to love each other with kind words and caring actions.

THE DEVOTIONAL

Through notes, lists, decorations, and Bible verses, we celebrate love in simple, everyday ways.

THE PRAYER

Thank You, Lord, for showing us how to love through kindness.

THE CONVERSATION

What's one way you'll show love today?

FRIDAY AT A GLANCE

THE VERSE

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THE PRAYER

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THE CONVERSATION

How will you celebrate God's Sabbath gift this week?

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THE VERSE

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THE DEVOTIONAL

God invites us to make Sabbath a day of delight—celebrating His love, creation, and family blessings.

THE PRAYER

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THE CONVERSATION

What is one way you'll make this Sabbath delightful?

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12501 Old Columbia Pike, Silver Spring, Maryland 20904, USA

301.680.6175 office

family@gc.adventist.org

family.adventist.org

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ISBN 978-0-8127-0585-0



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